

3.8.2 Externally Marked Route X (PSV/EMPA)

The practical and investigative skills will be assessed through

- Practical Skills Verification (PSV) and
- Externally Marked Practical Assignment (EMPA).

The PSV requires teachers to verify their candidates' ability to demonstrate safe and skilful practical techniques and make valid and reliable observations.

The EMPA has two stages where candidates

- Undertake a themed task
- Complete a written EMPA test

Each stage must be carried out under controlled

Further guidance for conducting practical activities for the PSV will be provided in the Teacher Resource Bank.

ICT

Candidates may use ICT where appropriate in the course of developing practical skills, for example in collecting and analysing data.

Externally Marked Practical Assignment (EMPA)

The Externally Marked Practical Assignment carries 50 marks and has two stages.

Stage 1: Themed task, collection and processing of data

Candidates carry out practical work following an AQA task sheet. The tasks may be conducted in a normal timetabled lesson and at a time convenient to the centre. Candidates collect raw data and represent it in a table of their own design or make observations that are recorded on the *Candidate Result Sheet*. The candidates' work must be handed to the teacher at the end of each session.

Centres may use the task sheets, as described, or may make minor suitable modifications to materials or equipment following AQA guidelines. Any modifications made to the task sheet must be agreed in writing with the Assessment Adviser and details must be provided to the AQA Examiner. The task may be conducted in a normal timetabled

There is no specified time limit for this stage.

Stage 2: The EMPA written test

The EMPA test should be taken as soon as convenient after completion of Stage 1 and under controlled conditions. Each candidate is provided with an EMPA test and the candidate's completed material from Stage 1.

The EMPA test is in three Sections.

Section A

This consists of a number of questions relating to the candidate's own data.

Section B

At the start of this section, candidates are supplied with additional data on a related topic. A number of questions relating to analysis and evaluation of the data then follow.

Section C

Candidates answer questions based knowledge and understanding of the processes outlined in section 3.3 for AS and section 3.6 for A2.

The number of marks allocated to each section may vary with each EMPA test.

Use of ICT during the EMPA

ICT may be used during the EMPA Stages 1 and 2 but teachers should note any restrictions in the Teachers' Notes. Use of the internet is not permitted.

Candidates absent for the practical work

A candidate absent for the practical work (Stage 1) should be given an opportunity to carry out the practical work before they sit the EMPA test. This may be with another group or at a different time. In extreme circumstances, when such arrangements are not possible the teacher may supply a candidate with class data. This must be noted on the *Candidate Record Form*. In this case the candidate cannot be awarded marks for Stage 1, but can still be awarded marks for Stage 2 of the assessment.

Material from AQA

For each EMPA, AQA will provide:

- Teachers' Notes
- Task sheet
- EMPA test

When received, this material must be kept under secure conditions. If it is to be used in more than one session, then the centre must ensure security of material between sessions. Further details regarding this material will be provided.

Security of assignments

Completed EMPAs should be treated like examination papers and kept under secure conditions until sent to the Examiner.

General Information Route X

Administration

Only one EMPA will be available in any year at AS and at A2. AQA will stipulate a period of time during which the EMPA (task and test) must be completed.

Candidates may make only one attempt at a particular EMPA and redrafting is not permitted at any stage during the EMPA.

Work to be submitted

The material to be submitted to the examiner for each candidate consists of

- the candidate's data from Stage 1 (on the *Candidate Result Sheet*)
- the EMPA written test and
- a *Candidate Record Form* including the PSV verification of safe and skilful practical techniques and reliable and valid observations.

In addition each centre must provide

- *Centre Declaration Sheet*
- Details of any amendments to the task sheet with confirmation supporting the changes from the Assessment Adviser.

Working in groups

For the PSV candidates may work in groups provided that any skills being assessed are the work of individual candidates. For the EMPA further guidance will be provided but the opportunity for group work will not be a common feature.

Other information

Section 6 of this specification outlines further guidance on the supervision and authentication of Internally assessed units.

Further support

AQA supports centres in a number of ways.

- A Teacher Resource Bank which includes further information and guidance